

Week 51 Honest measurement ranges

Facilitator guide | Final student packets v2 | Prepared 3 October 2026 | Unpiloted

Mathematical overview

Guaranteed intervals. If $a \in [L, U]$ and $b \in [V, W]$, then $a+b \in [L+V, U+W]$ and $a-b \in [L-W, U-V]$.

When a and b may vary freely in their separate closed intervals, these bounds are tight and both endpoints can occur. This is deterministic uncertainty: no probability distribution or confidence percentage is assumed.

“Always reaches r ” means the minimum is at least r ; “always fits within s ” means the maximum is at most s . Equality is allowed in both. Except when a problem explicitly asks for whole-unit pairs, hidden endpoints may lie anywhere in the band, including between ticks and at the edges. The cards stipulate guaranteed bounds; the ruler itself does not establish an instrument error bound.

Dependencies matter. Repeated A is one unchanged quantity. Thus $(A+4)-(A+1)=3$ and $(A+B)-A=B$. Using separate ranges for repeated copies can enclose the answer too broadly. A known relation such as $A+B=12$ restricts possible endpoint combinations. The elementary formulas remain enclosures, but need not remain tight when the variables are linked.

Discovery by band. K-1 builds extreme examples and tries to defeat “always” claims. Grades 2-3 designs the widest safe card and compares shared versus separate strips. Grades 4-5 tightens bounds using an exact total and shared-piece cancellation. Testing examples can disprove a claim; endpoint arguments prove a guarantee and its sharpness.

Prepare and launch

Per pair: printed pages, pencils, two sliding paper strips with opaque sleeves or a cover card, and a working ruler. Print at actual size: **one unit is 10 mm**, and each main 0-16 ruler is 160 mm long. Prepare exact white add-ons of 4 units (40 mm) and 1 unit (10 mm) for the shared-A page. A second copy of A must be set to the very same length, or use one physical A twice and mark both resulting ends.

Readiness. K-1 needs matching endpoints and counting small lengths, with adult reading. Older children need addition/subtraction and comparison of intervals. Negative numbers are unnecessary: in every printed gap task, the designated upper/longer join stays to the right. Keep an adult at each of the three tables.

Launch, 4 minutes. Let children slide an end inside its band. Show A from 2 to 3 and B from 1 to 2 using the printed visual: the shortest join is 3, longest 5. Try a different legal endpoint, and keep the join gap-free from 0. Ask, “Can you choose allowed lengths that break my promise?”

Flexible hour. 0-5 launch; 5-22 joins and adversarial tests; 22-25 stand and form shortest/longest human strips; 25-43 choose cards or compare shared pieces; 43-55 exchange guarantees with witnesses; 55-60 reset. Keep uncertain ranges visibly distinct from one actual trial.

Key for the join and card problems

Problem 1, all bands. A is 4-6 and B is 3-4, so the tight join range is **[7,10]**. Extremes are $4+3=7$ and $6+4=10$. K-1 can make exactly 8 with $4+4$ or $5+3$. In the older task, either extreme defeats the claimed 8-9 guarantee. Every sum lies in $[7,10]$, and both endpoints are allowed, so neither bound can improve.

Problem 2. Use only the three printed row pairs, not arbitrary cross-pairings.

Printed pair	Tight sum	Always reaches 8	Also fits within 10
A 4-6 with B 3-4	[7,10]	No: $4+3=7$	Yes
C 4-5 with D 4-5	[8,10]	Yes	Yes
E 6-8 with F 2-4	[8,12]	Yes	No: $8+4=12$

K-1 asks only about reaching 8, so **C with D and E with F** both work. Grades 2-3 and 4-5 require both promises, so **C with D alone** works. Reaching exactly 8 and ending exactly 10 count as successes. The endpoint witnesses in the table defeat the rejected guarantees.

Problem 3. Choose **B from 4 to 5**. With A from 3 to 4, all sums then lie in $[7,9]$. K-1's 3-4 card fails at $3+3=6$; its 5-6 card fails at $4+6=10$. In the older task, B's lower endpoint must be at least 4, because A might be 3; B's upper endpoint must be at most 5, because A might be 4. Hence $[4,5]$ is the unique widest interval.

Grades 2-3 and 4-5 Problem 4. Uncover **A**. Knowing $A=a$ leaves $[a+3, a+4]$, width 1. Knowing $B=b$ leaves $[b+4, b+6]$, width 2. Revealing the strip with the wider original range removes more uncertainty; the exact revealed value shifts the remaining range but does not change its width.

Key for shared and separate strips

K-1 Problem 4; older Problem 5. Top comparison: $A+4$ versus that same $A+1$. The end gap is always **3**; both smallest and largest gaps are 3, because the shared A cancels.

Bottom comparison: $A+4$ versus $B+1$, with A and B each separately allowed from 4 to 6. The tight gap is **[1,5]**. Minimum: $A=4, B=6$ gives $8-7=1$. Maximum: $A=6, B=4$ gives $10-5=5$. Intermediate values are possible too. The diagram shows one setting, not a promise that the shaded pieces always retain their drawn lengths.

Key for gaps and exact totals

K-1 Problem 5. The long strip is 7-9 and the short strip 5-6. Largest gap **4** occurs at 9-5; smallest gap **1** occurs at 7-6. Each end moves separately. Subtracting shortest from shortest would not give the smallest gap.

K-1 Problem 6. Two whole-unit ways to make gap 3 are **8-5** and **9-6**. With continuous endpoints, there are also intermediate choices such as 8.5-5.5; the prompt does not restrict this problem to whole units.

Grades 2-3 and 4-5 Problem 6. Long strip [13,15] minus short strip [10,12] has tight gap **[1,5]**. Use $13-12=1$ and $15-10=5$ to show both bounds are attained. Every allowed long length is at least 13 and every short one at most 12, so the difference is positive.

Grades 2-3 and 4-5 Problem 7. Subtracting middle values gives $14-11=3$, which is possible but not guaranteed. Either 13 and 12 (gap 1) or 15 and 10 (gap 5) defeats the assertion of one exact gap. No probabilistic claim makes the midpoint more authoritative.

K-1 Problem 7; Grades 2-3 Problem 8. With A from 4 to 6, B from 3 to 5, whole-unit lengths, and total 9, the complete list of ordered pairs (A,B) is **(4,5), (5,4), (6,3)**. These exhaust the three possible whole values of A, and each corresponding $B=9-A$ fits its card. The exact-sum condition links the strips.

Grades 4-5 Problem 8. $A \in [7,10]$, $B \in [3,7]$ and $A+B=12$ imply $B=12-A$. The B card restricts A to [5,9]; intersecting with A's card gives **$A \in [7,9]$** and consequently $B \in [3,5]$. Since A is always larger, the end gap is $A-B=2A-12$, ranging from **2 to 6**. Witnesses are $(A,B)=(7,5)$ and $(9,3)$. The discarded choice $A=10$ would require $B=2$ and is not allowed.

Grades 4-5 Problem 9. The tight remainder range is **[3,4]**, exactly B's original range. Physically remove the same A that was joined: all that remains is B. The claimed [1,6] is a valid but unnecessarily wide enclosure obtained by treating the total and A as freely variable. Its extreme combinations cannot occur together: a total of 7 requires $A=4, B=3$, while a total of 10 requires $A=6, B=4$.

Optional hints and source

For a guarantee, ask the partner to choose the most awkward permitted ends. For a tight bound, ask for a setting that actually reaches it. For dependency, keep a finger or matching label on the same A. If the group is still comparing physical extremes, stop there rather than require interval notation or algebra.

NIST Digital Library of Mathematical Functions, **§3.1(ii)**, "Interval Arithmetic," equation (3.1.6): [official reference](#). This is the current interval-arithmetic section; §3.1(v) is error measures. The strip endpoint calculations, repeated-variable cancellations and constrained-total cases here are independently derived. All dimensions were digitally checked; strip handling and the hour plan are unpiloted proposals.